Watching the spectacle, Friedrich Wolff thought the condition of the accused reminded him of the old East German joke about the start of central committee meetings. ‘First point of order: carry in the Politburo. Second point of order: plug in the pacemakers.’ As the courtroom grew hushed, the forty-nine charges of manslaughter related to escape attempts were reduced to thirteen to speed the trial. Although no document was found in which Honecker (or anyone else) explicitly ordered guards to fire at fleeing citizens, he supposedly endorsed the ‘unhampered use’ of firearms to prevent escapes during a meeting of the National Defence Council in May 1974.3

However, Hans Georg Brautigam, who led the three judges, ended the session almost as soon as it began to allow ailing Willi Stoph to undergo medical tests. When it recommenced, proceedings were halted again after Honecker suffered a bout of faintness. (The incident immediately touched off mischief, as anonymous letters were sent to several newspaper offices in Bonn and Berlin claiming the former GDR leader had died.)

From here on, the case never really gained steam. Affidavits assessing the state of Honecker’s health were repeatedly introduced, and on one occasion, a representative of one of the co-plaintiffs argued that Honecker was not suffering from cancer but rather a tapeworm, and even proposed that the man in the dock was not Honecker but a body double. Nicolas Becker recalled that:

The trial was exhausting for him, and his appearance deteriorated clearly from day to day. He was more and more marked by his illness. He never expressed fear to be found guilty, because he thought the trial to be a political trial and he considered the thesis of the prosecutors – that he had violated his own GDR-law by giving orders to prevent transgressions of the Wall by deadly force, if necessary – an ideological theory. On the other hand, the question of responsibility did not arise with Honecker, because who would be more responsible than him.4